Navigating Child Protection in Kampala, Uganda: Experiences, Perspectives and Strategies of Parents and Guardians Concerning Child Protection and their Engagement with the NGO, 'Kids Club Kampala'

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Abstract

This qualitative study investigates the impact of non-governmental organisation (NGO) support on child protection, focusing on experiences of parents and guardians in Kampala, Uganda. It utilises a case-study approach, centred on the NGO, Kids Club Kampala (KCK), to explore the perspectives, strategies, and perceptions of parents and guardians regarding child protection and their engagement with the NGO's initiatives. Using an intersectional framework, the study thematically analyses data from 21 semi-structured interviews, conducted across three slum communities and one village in Kampala.

The findings reveal that parents and guardians in these settings express a strong desire for additional parent-skills training on child protection measures for the home environment, outside of KCK's direct projects. While they report high satisfaction with the support their children receive from KCK, significant barriers within the home and community affect their ability to implement these protective strategies. The study identifies a pervasive cycle of generational abuse, predominantly physical, which parents and guardians recognise and desire to break. However, they indicate a critical need for enhanced resources and parental-training to interrupt this cycle.

In conclusion, the research argues that the intersection of complex challenges, including financial poverty, lack of access to education and healthcare, urban-slum flooding, and generational abuse, impact the ability of parents and guardians to protect children. Future research should consider comparative case-studies in different cultural and geographical contexts to test the generalisability of the findings, and employ quantitative methods, such as surveys, to triangulate the data.

Definitions

The primary concepts and terms central to this study have been defined by adopting and adapting widely accepted scholarly definitions to align with the specific context of this research. These concepts are summarised in **Table 1**.

Table 1

Concept definitions

Concept	Definition
Child protection:	Involves the systems and measures put in place to prevent and respond to abuse, neglect, exploitation, violence, and harmful practices against children. This includes advocating for and protecting children from all forms of discrimination, ensuring they have immediate access to necessary services, and promoting solutions that are always in the child's best interests. *(Windle International Uganda 2021; Save the Children, 2007; UNHCR, 2025; UNICEF, 2025)*
Informal child protection:	Encompasses all family-based care and community-led initiatives that work to ensure children's well-being and safety outside of a formal, state-regulated system. A key component of this is family care, which involves a child being raised by a member of their extended family or by a close, known family friend, often without legal formalities. This broader, community-driven approach also includes efforts by neighbours and children themselves to strengthen families, promote a child's welfare, and respond to instances of mistreatment. While typically operating outside of formal systems, key figures from these informal networks, such as community leaders, may be integrated as stakeholders within official child protection frameworks *(Save the Children, 2019; Guga et al., 2009; Alliance, 2019).*
Formal child protection:	A comprehensive and sustainable set of structures, functions, mechanisms or processes to prevent and respond to child protection concerns. This includes laws, policies, regulations, and services. Many definitions assume that the government is ultimately responsible for supervision and regulation, though community, international individuals and NGOs can be involved in implementation *(Guga et al., 2009; Alliance, 2019).*
Guardian:	A person who has been given the legal authority to care for a child and make decisions on their behalf, typically because the parents are unable to do so. This legal relationship, known as guardianship, gives the guardian parental responsibilities, and sometimes the power to manage the child's finances, until the child is old enough to act for themselves *(GOVUK, 2024; Kityo, 2024).*

Abbreviations

CRC - Convention on the Rights of the Child

CT - Child trafficking

EBPPs - Evidence-based parenting programmes

ECD - Early childhood development

FGM - Female genital mutilation

GBV - Gender-based violence

KCK - Kids Club Kampala

LICs - Low-income countries

NGO - Non-governmental organisation

Parents/guardians – Parents and guardians

SV - Sexual violence

VAC - Violence against children

Chapter 1: Introduction

Parents and guardians (parents/guardians) have a profound influence over a child's development, their protection against societal dangers, and their future prospects (Gadsden et al., 2016; OECD, 2024). The absence of adequate parental care is identified as a predominant concern impacting children globally (Save the Children, 2012). While instances of inadequate parenting can stem from intentional neglect, a significant proportion arises from external barriers beyond parental control (Musendo, 2024). Barriers include financial poverty, family breakdown, health crises, limited access to education, political instability, natural disasters, discrimination, and rapid urbanisation and migration, which are often compounded by low parental confidence (Musendo, 2024; Save the Children, 2015). Furthermore, the effectiveness of parental efforts to protect their children is undermined by a lack of consistent policy and practical support for parental involvement, limiting opportunities for engagement in child protection initiatives (Musendo, 2024).

Inadequate parenting is evident in urban centres such as Kampala, Uganda, where children navigate intersecting risks across their developmental stages (UNICEF, 2025). Critical issues in health, education, and protection manifest as vulnerabilities, including high rates of school dropouts, teenage pregnancy, child labour, physical and sexual abuse, and neglect (Horn et al., 2013; Wessells, 2015). These challenges extend beyond individual instances of abuse, to pervasive systemic issues such as child-trafficking (CT) and female genital mutilation (FGM) (Klabbers, 2023). The long-lasting consequences of such violence impact children's mental and physical health, hinder educational attainment, and increase risks of substance abuse, suicidal behaviour, and criminal involvement (Ellermeijer et al., 2023).

In response to these challenges, the Government of Uganda and UNICEF's current country programme (2021-2025) prioritises education, child and social protection. This initiative, embedded within Uganda's Vision 2040 and national development plans, aims to educate parents/guardians to understand their rights, report violations, and ensure access to protection services through the promotion of positive parenting practices (UNICEF, 2025).

Despite significant efforts to enhance parental skills and knowledge in child protection, physical violence remains prevalent in Uganda, affecting 59% of girls and 68% of boys (Save the Children International, 2024). Gender-based violence (GBV) and sexual violence (SV) are

also widespread, with 35% of girls and 17% of boys experiencing SV during childhood (Save the Children International, 2024). Girls face heightened vulnerability to child marriage, teenage pregnancy, and FGM, with statistics indicating that one in four teenage girls are pregnant or already mothers in Uganda (UNICEF, 2025). Worsening these persistent challenges are emerging threats such as online dangers, particularly sexual exploitation, and increasing vulnerability brought about by climate change impacts like urban slum flooding (Government of Uganda, 2020; UNICEF, 2017).

The Ugandan National Child Policy (2020) attributes increasing child vulnerability to multiple interconnected issues rooted in parental practices. Addressing the interconnected issues necessitates an intersectional framework. This approach is vital for social justice initiatives, including NGO interventions, as many are often designed around single-issue categories like "women" or "the poor," potentially overlooking complex realities (Collins, 2015; UNICEF, 2023). Parents/guardians in Kampala possess multiple, overlapping identities, encompassing factors such as ethnicity, gender, socio-economic status and education level, which shape their lived experiences (Thomas et al., 2023; Holman & Walker, 2021; Phoenix, 2006). Given that parental beliefs and caregiving methods are profoundly shaped by cultural context (Lansford, 2022), an intersectional framework will explore the overlapping factors that create unique barriers for parents/guardians to effectively protect their children (Grünenfelder and Schurr, 2015; Mügge et al., 2018).

Poverty correlates directly with various child rights violations in Uganda (UNICEF, 2015; World Bank, 2016). While 20.3% of Ugandans live below the national income poverty line, 64.82% endure multidimensional poverty, experiencing deprivations across multiple critical areas including health, education, and living standards. Children within these households are more susceptible to abuse, exploitation, and family separation (OPHI, 2022; UNDP, 2023). This reality underscores the broader scope of deprivations that impact a parent's capacity to provide a protective environment within the unique urban dynamics of Kampala (Atamanov, 2016; Ellis and Bahiigwa, 2003).

A critical gap exists between international policy, NGO action, and the realities of local communities. While the 1989 Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC) prioritises parents as primary protectors (Save the Children International, 2023), its universalist stance has been criticised for failing to address the socio-cultural realities of many African states (Adu-Gyamfi and Keating, 2013). This includes concepts like 'Obuntu,' where child-rearing is a collective

community responsibility (Mugumbate et al., 2024; Renzaho et al., 2018). In contexts like Kampala, NGOs often focus on short-term impact, neglecting to equip parents with long-term strategies for use at home (Ellermeijer et al., 2023; UNICEF, 2025). Reliance on NGOs and practices like "voluntourism" raises concerns about the sustainability and capacity-building of interventions (Sullivan, 2019; Wearing and McGehee, 2013).

This research is conducted in partnership with KCK, a community-led NGO dedicated to supporting vulnerable children, young people and their families across ten of Kampala's slum-settlements (KCK, 2025). KCK prioritises community outreach, protection, education, and skills training, distinguished by its close collaboration with local leaders and a commitment to incorporating beneficiary needs and ideas (VASHI, 2023). These values are central to KCK's holistic initiatives which are encapsulated in their aim, mission and vision statement (**Table 2**). **Figure 1** shows the areas where KCK operates, and four specific sites where the researcher conducted the study.

Table 2

KCK's aim, mission and vision

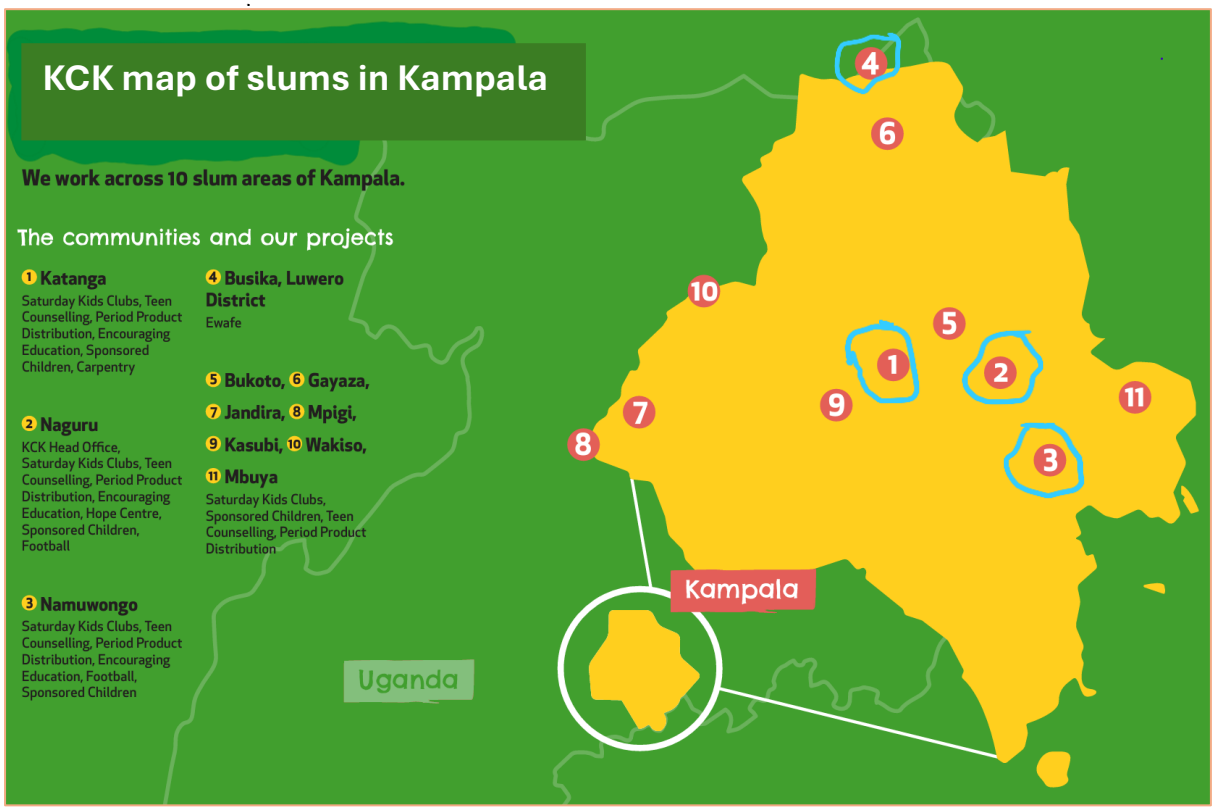
Aspirations	Description
Aim	Working together to help vulnerable children and young people aged 2-18, and their families living in Kampala's slums to survive and thrive.
Mission	To support vulnerable children in Uganda. Providing for both their immediate needs and strengthening their futures through community outreach, protecting, educating and skilling.
Vision	To see children's lives transformed, communities empowered, and poverty reduced throughout Uganda.

KCK (2023) adapted by author

Details of KCK programmes are provided in **Appendix 1.**

Figure 1

Map of slum areas where KCK operates, and areas where research undertaken



NOTE: Areas circled in blue are where observations and interviews were conducted.

KCK Impact Report (2023) adapted by author

This research aims to explore the experiences, perspectives, and strategies of parents/guardians in Kampala concerning child protection, with a particular focus on their perceptions of and engagement with KCK's initiatives in supporting these efforts. By focusing on the complex socio-cultural, familial, and economic realities in Kampala's slum settlements, this study provides nuanced insights into parental experiences of child protection.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

2. 1 Child neglect: The role of parents and guardians

Child neglect, a significant form of child maltreatment, occurs when parents/guardians fail to provide fundamental necessities such as shelter, food, and schooling (Save the Children, 2012). A key challenge, particularly in African contexts, is the perception held by parents regarding the risks children face. Ige and Fawole's (2011) research in Nigeria revealed that many parents believe their children are immune to abuse. Parental deficiencies are consistently linked to a lack of willingness, insufficient understanding of child welfare, or economic constraints (Kithome et al., 2021; Renzaho et al., 2018; Save the Children, 2012).

Children experiencing neglect often internalise their predicament but, when able to seek assistance, primarily turn to their parents, who are considered the first response in child protection (Justice with Children, 2020; Kafuko et al., 2015). Without parental intervention, children frequently conceal their neglect, sometimes leaving school for employment or marriage in search of stability (Kafuko et al., 2015). Kafuko et al. (2015) note that parental indifference toward education, often rooted in their own limited schooling, can be as detrimental as the inability to afford school fees.

By engaging parents in community groups to address child protection, communities can foster a sense of shared responsibility, and raise awareness of ongoing child protection violations (Save the Children, 2012). While the inclusion of children in welfare decisions is well-established, it is not the same for parents (Balsellsa et al., 2017). Smithson and Gibson (2020) argue that a robust child protection framework must include the perspectives of children and parents. The authoritarian nature of some formal child protection interventions often marginalises parental voices, which can lead to a cycle of conflict between parents, children, and authorities (Smithson and Gibson, 2020). Kafuko et al. (2015) conclude that resolving child protection issues amicably requires greater cooperation and willingness from parents.

A 2012 study on community-based child protection in Uganda found that involving external authorities like the police should be avoided, as arresting a parent might prolong neglect. However, a respondent suggested that the embarrassment and legal pressure of court proceedings could renew a parent's commitment (Save the Children, 2012). Rather than expending police time on cases where parental training could be more effective, exploring less

disciplinary and more supportive interventions may lead to better outcomes for children's protection (Kafuko et al., 2015).

2.1.1 The intergenerational cycle of abuse

GBV and violence against children (VAC) are closely interlinked, sharing many risk factors and often occurring in the same households (Kithome et al., 2021). In Uganda, physical violence predominantly originates from parents/guardians (Wight et al., 2022). The intergenerational transmission of abuse is a critical concern, with parenting practices, especially in early childhood, identified as a key mechanism in child development (Wight et al., 2022). Saitadze and Dvalishvili (2024) emphasise the co-occurrence of abuses, highlighting the need for intersectional approaches to prevention (Kithome et al., 2021).

The prevalence of GBV and VAC in informal settlements is well-documented (Wight et al., 2022). A study in Uganda described the risk to children, especially girls, of being raped when walking alone at night, noting that it is often parents who have asked the child to go out after dark to purchase something (Save the Children, 2012). Furthermore, despite its abolition in schools, corporal punishment remains widely accepted in homes (Justice with Children, 2020). A respondent from that study noted that a lack of parental sex education leaves children without essential knowledge about reproduction and family planning, increasing their vulnerability to pregnancy and STIs (Save the Children, 2012).

2.2 Parental barriers: The capacity to protect children

Parents often face systemic challenges like financial and multi-dimensional poverty, and family instability (Save the Children, 2015; World Bank, 2016). These issues are compounded by low parental confidence and high levels of stress (Musendo, 2024; Saitadze and Dvalishvili, 2024). A parent's psychological well-being significantly impacts their parenting practices, with studies directly linking depression to abusive behaviours (Huang, 2018). Increasing parental confidence and reducing stress can lead to significant positive changes within family dynamics, improving child protection beyond NGO interventions (ICSAfrica, 2016). Wight et al. (2022) emphasise that a caring relationship with parents/guardians is crucial for mitigating the impact of community dangers. They also suggest that including both mothers and fathers in parental training can boost confidence and encourage them to find their own solutions.

Limited parental involvement remains a key issue in child protection (Musendo, 2024). A study in Malawi, using the COM-B model (Capability, Opportunity, Motivation, Behaviour), explored the barriers influencing parental involvement in the protection of children with disabilities (Musendo, 2024). The study found that while parents showed a strong sense of responsibility, they faced significant barriers, including a lack of knowledge about their children's specific needs, time constraints, low confidence, and financial challenges. Musendo (2024) notes that schools often limit parental participation due to a lack of consistent policies and actions to support it.

A research gap exists concerning how parental barriers influence early childhood development in the Global South, as most studies on parental capacity in child protection have focused on high-income settings and older children (Musendo, 2024; Huang et al., 2018). Musendo (2024) noted a lack of evidence on the unique cultural, and financial factors influencing parental involvement in low-income countries (LICs), information critical for developing targeted, context-appropriate interventions.

Musendo's study highlights the complex link between parental knowledge, practical constraints, and external support systems. The research advocates for parent-focused interventions that enhance parental literacy, improve access to resources, shift societal attitudes, and address barriers like time constraints by establishing peer support systems and fostering positive school-home relationships (Musendo, 2024).

2.3 Strengthening parents: The role of external support

2.3.1 Community-based mechanisms

Effective child protection necessitates robust community-based mechanisms to prevent child abuse and provide support (Save the Children, 2012). Research shows that enhanced access to support systems, including informal child protection services, can reduce parental isolation and stress, leading to better parenting and a lower likelihood of child maltreatment (Thompson, 2015; Byrne et al., 2012). Community programmes offer opportunities for parents to connect, learn about positive parenting, and improve child safety (Saitadze and Dvalishvili, 2024).

Evidence also demonstrates that social protection measures, such as parental skills training, improve child protection outcomes and make children less prone to physical abuse (Save the Children, 2019). However, informal social support can sometimes be negative, as a failure to

react to harmful parenting may increase the likelihood of child maltreatment (Saitadze and Dvalishvili, 2024; Thompson, 2015). Similarly, some NGOs have been found to prioritise their visibility over long-term protection outcomes (Justice with Children Report, 2020). Despite growing research, a research gap persists, as the literature often focuses on process rather than the actual outcomes for children, parents, and communities (Ellermeijer et al., 2023).

2.3.2 Preventative interventions

Effective child protection relies on equipping parents with knowledge and skills to identify and respond to child rights violations (Wulczyn et al., 2010). Key familial predictors of VAC include poor parent-child attachment, harsh parenting, and parental conflict (Wight et al., 2022). In response, researchers in Uganda have developed culturally sensitive, community-based parenting programmes. Evidence-based parenting programmes (EBPPs) are effective at changing parenting behaviours and reducing child maltreatment (Doyle et al., 2023). Strengthening parent-child relationships and expanding available services are essential for changing norms that predispose children to abuse (Kafuko et al., 2015; Wessells, 2015).

Despite extensive research on their effectiveness, EBPPs are not widely available at a population level, particularly in LICs. A gap exists between what is known in the literature and what is supported by policy, which appears to hinder the broad implementation of these programmes (Doyle et al., 2023).

Effective parent programmes feature enhanced communication, shared decision-making, and non-violent disciplinary methods (Wight et al., 2022). Positive parent-child relationships and parental awareness of child development are crucial for reducing child maltreatment (Wessells, 2015; Wight et al., 2022). Research in Uganda shows that some parents lack the agency to guide and protect their children (Kafuko et al., 2015). The CRC recommends family-strengthening services like parenting courses to enhance parental capacity (UNICEF, 1989). Such recommendations include training of maternal and paternal figures to embrace their parenting responsibility (Kafuko et al., 2015).

Despite this, targeted policies and programme for parental education in child protection are lacking (Save the Children, 2015). Research on parent confidence and ability to prevent child protection issues is also limited, particularly in Kampala's slum settlements (Kafuko et al., 2015). While many studies document the dangers children face, few address preventative actions by parents (Nakibuuka and Nalubega, 2022; Ssensamba et al., 2019). Recommendations from bodies like the African Children's Committee often lack an explicit

focus on directly equipping parents with the necessary knowledge and skills (Metz, 2011; Kafuko et al., 2015).

2.4 Moving beyond western dominance: A culturally informed approach

Wessells' (2015) study found that local people's views on harm to children often differ from international standards, highlighting the issue of Western concepts being imposed on local communities. Respondents in the study did not mention FGM or CT, despite their prevalence in Sierra Leone. This disparity necessitates an investigation into parental perceptions of terms like 'child protection' (Wessells, 2015; Renzaho et al., 2018).

The CRC has been widely criticised for advancing a Western notion of childhood that fails to consider the sociocultural realities of African countries (Adu-Gyamfi and Keating, 2013; Renzaho et al., 2018). Many African states felt the convention inadequately addressed their concerns, as human rights discourse often overlooks the Global South (Adu-Gyamfi and Keating, 2013).

Child protection needs vary across regions, necessitating context-specific systems (Kithome et al., 2021). As a participatory framework, intersectionality can mitigate the oversight of international standards by moving beyond broad generalisations to address specific, compounded forms of injustice (Collins et al., 2021; Grünenfelder & Schurr, 2015). This approach promotes understanding of subgroup inequalities and challenges unrepresentative international standards (Holman et al., 2021; Funer, 2023).

Emerging evidence suggests that context-relevant, culturally sensitive parenting programmes in the Global South can significantly improve child outcomes when delivered by trained local facilitators (Musendo, 2024; Wight et al., 2022). Programmes like ICSAfrica's "Skilful Parenting Programme" have demonstrated enhanced parental competence and a shift toward non-violent discipline by focusing on local culture and participatory approaches (ICSAfrica, 2016).

2.5 Rationale for this research

Building on these insights, this study will explore parental perceptions and experiences of child protection in Kampala, with a focus on their perceptions of and engagement with KCK's

initiatives. By examining these elements, the study seeks to address the identified research gaps and contribute to a deeper understanding of the intersecting factors that impact parents' capacity to protect children. Given the tendency to over-rely on Western-based structures of child protection, this study will explore the extent to which KCK's interventions are integrated into existing community structures (Kithome et al., 2021; Wulczyn et al., 2010).

Chapter 3: Theoretical Framework: Intersectionality

Intersectionality recognises that individuals' multiple overlapping identities such as race, gender, sexuality and income status, intersect to create unique experiences of privilege and oppression (Collins, 2015; Holman & Walker, 2021; Thomas et al., 2023).

Originating from Black Feminism, intersectionality was a vital tool to understand how women of colour experience both racism and sexism simultaneously (Brahm, 2019; Crenshaw, 1989). Treating identities as mutually exclusive categories leads to marginalisation and can harm those affected by multiple forms of injustice (Crenshaw, 1989; Brahm, 2019).

In Kampala, factors like coordination gaps, cultural issues, and poverty hinder child rights, necessitating an intersectional analysis of child protection (Renzaho et al., 2018). While 'issue-based' efforts have produced benefits, they often result in a fragmented and inefficient response, leaving 'pockets of unmet need' by failing to account for the multiple, overlapping realities children and parents face (Wulczyn et al., 2010).

Intersectionality is increasingly recognised in international development, moving beyond single-focus approaches to provide tailored interventions for specific, intersecting needs (Grünenfelder & Schurr, 2015; Mügge et al., 2018).

The African Children's Committee (2025) discuss the overlapping factors contributing to children's vulnerability, calling for an examination of vulnerabilities to inform effective preventative action. An intersectional lens can lead to more precise, humane and effective child protection solutions than existing, generalised approaches (Mügge et al., 2018; Steele, 2025).

Chapter 4: Research Aim and Questions

4.1 Research Aim

This research aims to explore the experiences, perspectives, and strategies of parents and guardians in Kampala concerning child protection, with a particular focus on their perceptions of and engagement with KCK's initiatives in supporting these efforts, and the factors influencing these perceptions.

4.2 Research Questions

1. What are the experiences, perspectives, and strategies employed by parents and guardians in Kampala to protect their children and why?
2. How does KCK facilitate child protection, and how do parents and guardians in Kampala perceive and attribute its role in supporting their child protection efforts?
3. What are KCK's key objectives and strategies for offering support to parents and guardians alongside their child protection programmes in Kampala and why?

Chapter 5: Methodology

5.1 Research Design

This study adopts a qualitative research design to explore the complex, subjective, and lived experiences of parents/guardians concerning child protection in Kampala. This approach allows for a nuanced understanding that quantitative methods might not capture (Flick, 2018; Bryman, 2007).

An intersectional framework is adopted to recognise the interconnectedness of social identities, and the complexities of research participants in Kampala (Collins, 2015; Flynn and Slayter, 2023). Triangulation will be employed to enhance the credibility and trustworthiness of the findings and mitigate potential biases arising from a single data source (Bowling, 2014; Flick, 2018; Herbet, 2000; Ratan, 2019).

Figure 2 shows a Gantt Chart to represent the key phases of the research process. Overall, this qualitative design enables an in-depth exploration of parental perceptions, strategies, and engagement with child protection and KCK.

Figure 2

Key phases of research process

	MONTH								
	2025								
Research Phase	**Jan**	**Feb**	**Mar**	**Apr**	**May**	**Jun**	**Jul**	**Aug**	**Sep**
Phase 1: Desk-based analysis of secondary documents									
Phase 2: Academic literature review									
Phase 3: Field observations in Uganda for contextualisation									
Phase 4: Conducting semi-structured interviews									
Phase 5: Thematic Analysis									
Phase 6: Reflexive journalling									

Author (2025)

5.2 Data Collection Methods

5.2.1 Phases 1 and 2: Desk-Based Research and Literature Review

This study commenced with desk-based research to obtain secondary data providing contextual information about KCK's operations. This involved a systematic review of KCK's internal documents, including impact reports, casefiles and child protection materials. Integrating these multiple data sources facilitated triangulation, which enhanced the credibility of the research and complemented a detailed literature review (Bowling, 2014; Flick, 2018; Herbet, 2000).

5.2.2 Phase 3: Field observations in Uganda for contextualisation

Eight days of KCK project observation were conducted by the researcher prior to interviews. This gave the researcher the opportunity to see KCK projects, including EWAFE, Early Childhood Development (ECD), Saturday Kids Club and Skilling projects, in operation. These additional observations enhanced internal validity by immersing the researcher in the Ugandan context and providing a better understanding of KCK's initiatives (Bannigan and Watson, 2009).

5.2.3 Phase 4: Semi-structured interviews

Semi-structured interviews with open-ended questions were used to facilitate a participant-centred discussion, allowing for question modification and follow-up inquiries (Pope, 2008; May, 2011). This conversational style encouraged authentic responses and provided the flexibility to explore emergent themes while ensuring key research questions were covered (Bowling, 2014; Bryman, 2007).

Purposive sampling selected respondents aged 18 or above who were parents/guardians in Kampala. Maximum variation sampling was employed to ensure a diverse representation across age, gender, family dynamics, financial status, religion, and location. This enhanced the study's relevance to the lived experiences of those in Kampala's slum settlements (Bryman, 2007; Thomas et al., 2023; Twyman et al., 1999).

KCK staff identified and provided respondents via phone, with some informing other community members, which resulted in a snowball sampling effect. This method was useful given the sensitive nature of the research topic (Noy, 2008).

In total, 21 semi-structured interviews were conducted: 16 with parents/guardians, two with KCK project alumni, and three with KCK staff. **Tables 3, 4 and 5** provide details of respondents.

Table 3

Parent and guardian respondents and demographics: P1 = parent 1

Respondent	Age	Gender	Occupation	Married	Child	Education	Religion	Location
P1	49	F	Tailoring	N	4	Senior	Christian	Bukoola village
P2	18	F	Sells mangoes	N	1	None	Christian	Naguru slum
P3	40	F	Salon	Y	1	Senior	Christian	Naguru slum
P4	53	F	Cook	Y	2	Primary 5	Christian	Naguru slum
P5	35	M	Security	Y	3	Senior	Christian	Naguru slum
P6	29	F	Teacher	Y	4	Senior	Christian	Naguru slum
P7	34	M	Teacher	Y	4	Senior	Christian	Naguru slum
P8	35	F	Teacher	Y	2	Senior	Christian	Naguru slum
P9	25	F	None	N	1	Senior 4	Christian	Naguru slum
P10	38	F	Market	N	4	Primary	Christian	Kanyanya slum
P11	29	F	Market	Y	3	Senior 4	Christian	Kanyanya slum
P12	39	F	Washing clothes	N	3	Primary 5	Christian	Kanyanya slum
P13	42	F	Market	Y	3	Senior	Muslim	Kanyanya slum
P14	29	F	Market	Y	6	Primary	Christian	Katanga slum
P15	53	M	Farmer	Y	12	Senior	Christian	Bukoola village
P16	35	F	Selling food	Y	12	Senior 4	Christian	Bukoola village

Author (2025)

Table 4

KCK Alumni (previous participants of KCK now over 18) respondents and demographics: A1 = alumni 1

Respondent	Age	Gender	Occupation	Married	Children	Education	Religion	Location
A1	20	F	Mother	N	1	Senior	Christian	Katanga slum
A2	22	F	Mother	N	1	Primary	Christian	Katanga slum

Author (2025)

Table 5

KCK staff respondents and relevant demographic characteristics

Respondent	Job Title	KCK Programme
KCK 1	Safeguarding Officer/ Project Coordinator	Keeping Children Safe
KCK 2	Project Coordinator	EWAFE Abandoned Children
KCK 3	Project Coordinator	Access to Education

Author, (2025)

One-on-one interviews were conducted to facilitate the sharing of sensitive information that participants might have been uncomfortable discussing in a focus group (Dahlberg and McCaig, 2016).

Prior to each one-hour interview, verbal informed consent was obtained, with translators providing a written information sheet to ensure clarity.

All interviews were audio-recorded, and the transcripts were reviewed and edited for accuracy within one hour of completion using Otter.ai.

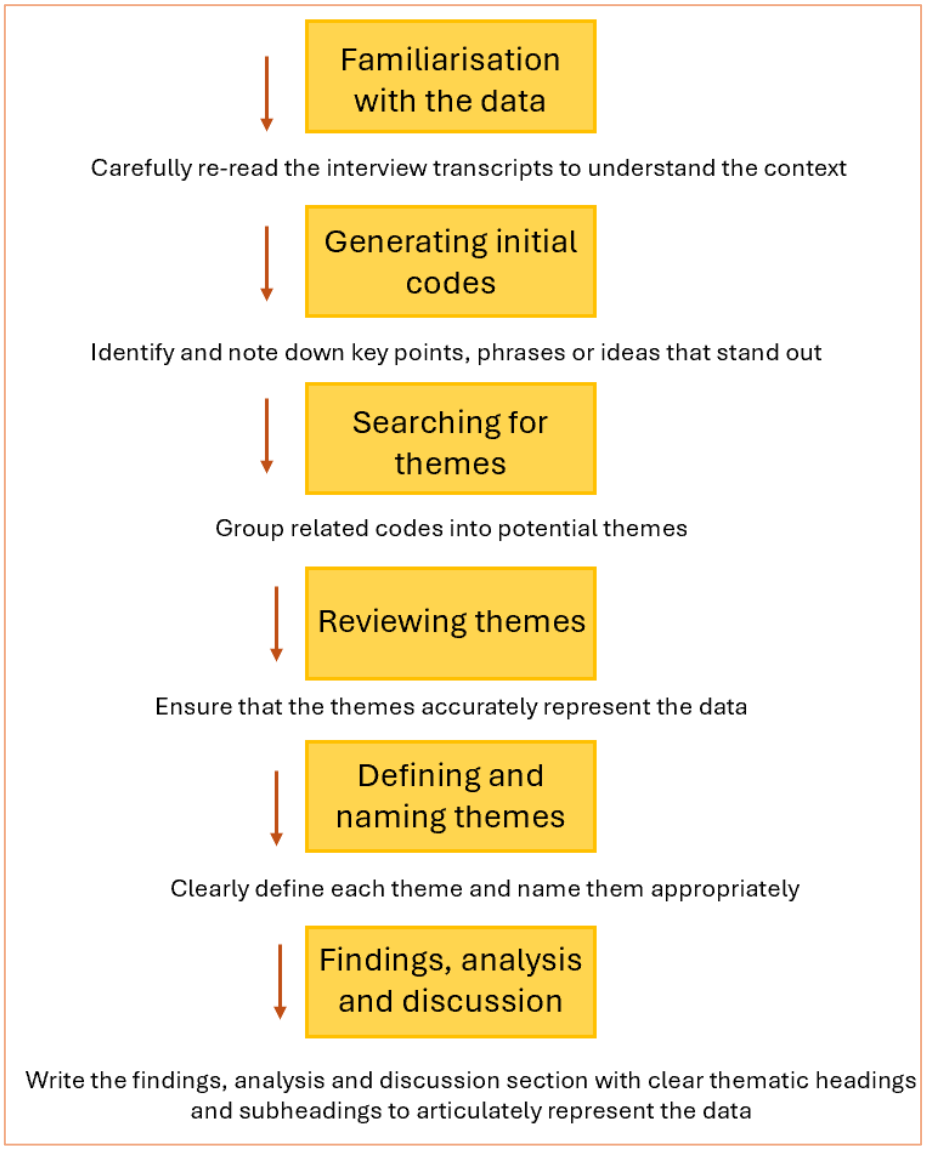
The researcher maintained a neutral, non-judgmental stance while adapting to participant language to allow for the authentic exploration of emerging themes (Rose & Johnson, 2020). Notepad observations were used to supplement the audio-recordings and provide contextual insights (Bowling, 2014).

5.3 Phase 5: Data Analysis using Thematic Analysis

Thematic Analysis was conducted using using NVIVO qualitative data analysis software to generate and organise codes. **Figure 3** shows a Thematic Analysis model used for this study. This process involved transcript familiarisation, followed by code generation and refinement. Themes were then developed, ensuring each theme accurately represented the data (Marshall & Rossman, 2020; Tambun et al., 2024).

Figure 3

Thematic Analysis Model used in this study



Tambun et al. (2024) adapted by author

Thematic Analysis revealed new perceptions from interview responses. The coding process remained adaptable to new findings as they became apparent in the data, and an inductive approach enabled themes to emerge naturally rather than from predefined categories (Marshall & Rossman, 2020).

5.4 Phase 6: Positionality and Reflexivity

Critical reflexivity, examining researcher biases, was employed throughout this study (Guillemin and Gillam, 2004; Sultana, 2015). Recognising the researcher's 'outsider' position (white woman) in Kampala, potential biases related to ethnicity, age, gender, and interview power dynamics were assessed pre, during, and post-data collection (Sultana, 2015). Reflexivity was documented through a reflective journal, detailed field notes, and feedback from a KCK mentor in the UK and KCK staff in Kampala. An intersectional lens addressed potential inequities, ensuring diverse voices were heard (Bannigan & Watson, 2009; Thomas et al., 2023).

The researcher's outsider position conducting interviews with market stall vendors introduced complexities that required constant reflexive consideration. Despite their ability to continue serving customers and the researcher's offers to pause the interview or relocate, the visible presence of the researcher alongside the shop owner may have inadvertently deterred some potential customers.

This experience highlighted the ethical imperative to minimise any negative impact of research on participants' livelihoods, especially in economically sensitive environments (Gillan and Pickerill, 2012; Sultana, 2015). This reflexive awareness led to more flexible interview methods and a heightened sensitivity to the interview context (Sultana, 2015).

5.4.1 Examples of mitigating power dynamics in this study

Language barriers were addressed using a translator, with careful efforts to ensure culturally sensitive language was used (Gillan & Pickerill, 2012).

Recognising potential power dynamics associated with English as a dominant language (Gebremariam, 2021; Bhakuni and Abimbola, 2021), the researcher always offered translation support. The sensitive nature of discussions around child maltreatment was addressed by maintaining a neutral, non-judgmental stance and by reminding respondents of their right to withdraw.

To avoid epistemic injustice and ensure the cultural context of Kampala was central, a diverse range of literature and secondary data were used (Bhakuni & Abimbola, 2021). The researcher attended a local lecture to better understand adult and child vulnerabilities in Kampala.

Throughout the research, participant inclusivity and accessibility were prioritised. A proactive approach, including the preparation of visual aids and ensuring an intersectional framework, ensured that all participants could contribute comfortably and effectively (Mock et al., 2017).

5.5 Ethical Considerations

This study received ethical approval from the University of Sheffield Research Ethics Committee. To ensure the rights and well-being of all participants, a comprehensive consent process was followed. Prior to each interview, participants were shown a detailed information sheet and a consent form, and verbal consent was obtained. Participants were informed of their right to withdraw at any time and were provided with a named contact at KCK and the University of Sheffield for any concerns.

The confidentiality and privacy of all participants were a priority. All collected data were securely stored and anonymised to prevent identification (Gillan and Pickerill, 2012; Wiles, 2013). Access was strictly limited to the researcher, dissertation supervisor, and KCK staff for analysis purposes, and all personal data will be destroyed three months after the dissertation's submission date.

Chapter 6: Research Findings, Analysis and Discussion

6.1 Thematic Analysis

6.1.1 Code generation

Table 6 shows 28 codes that were identified from the interview responses with a description of their meaning and how many times they were referred to by respondents.

Table 6

Codes identified from the interview responses

Code	*Code title*	*Description*	*Number of times issue referred to*
1	Abuse	Physical, emotional, sexual	19
2	Alternative discipline	Alternative to physical punishment such as beating e.g. limiting screen time	11
3	Challenges for children	Dangers or challenges that cause emotional, mental or physical harm to children	62
4	Challenges for girls	Dangers or challenges that cause emotional, mental or physical harm to girls such as issues related to menstrual hygiene	13
5	Challenges for parents	Dangers or challenges that cause emotional, mental or physical harm to parents which subsequently affect their ability to protect their children e.g. financial poverty	26
6	Changes wanted for children	Parental visions for child outcomes e.g. safer housing so that when it floods the children aren't homeless and therefore sick	12
7	Changes wanted for parents	Parental visions for enhanced ability to protect children e.g. more financial support to send a child to school so they are safe from community dangers	40
8	Dangerous travel	e.g. flooded roads cause drowning risk to children	16
9	Definition of child protection	Different perceptions of the meaning of 'child protection' or 'keeping children safe'	23
10	Enjoying education	Recognition of the importance of education	6
11	Familial love	Love from family members impacting parental ability to protect children	3
12	Family support	Support from family members impacting parental ability to protect children	10
13	Financial struggles	Lack of income impacting parental ability to protect children	20
14	Generational influence	Influence of a parent's upbringing on the way they parent their children	26

15	Gratitude	Respondent's thanking KCK	4
16	Health access	Example of poor health access is hospitals being too far away/ inaccessible.	6
17	How to protect children	Strategies for child protection by parents and guardians e.g. children walking together	56
18	Inadequate housing	Poor housing infrastructure that is susceptible to breaking during floods	7
19	Independence	Parents protecting their children without the support of others	1
20	KCK training for parents	KCK provisions for parents to enhance their ability to protect children	18
21	KCK impact	Parental perceptions of the impact of KCK's support	27
22	KCK support for children	KCK's child protection programmes	18
23	KCK support for parents	KCK's initiatives to support parents to protect their children	32
24	Lack of food	Impact of no food on child outcomes and parental ability to protect their children	8
25	Parental life experience	Parents' upbringings and the way they were raised	18
26	Pride	Parents feeling proud about the way they protect children	1
27	WASH	The impact of water, sanitation and hygiene on children and on parental ability to protect children	6
28	Working together	Community and families working together to protect children	13

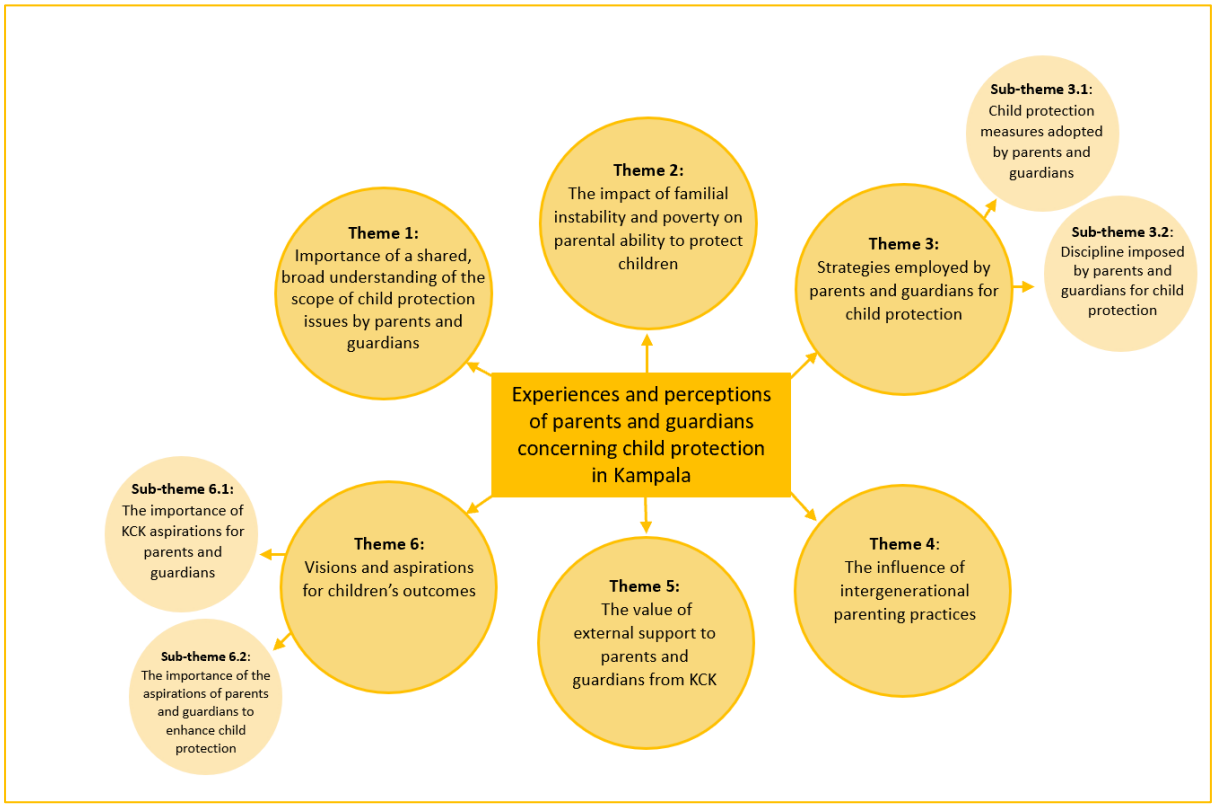
Author (2025)

6.1.2 Theme generation

Following the code generation, 6 themes were generated. **Figure 4** presents a diagram showing the themes and sub-themes chosen after code identification and code collation.

Figure 4

Final themes and sub-themes selected after code identification and code collation.



Author (2025)

6.2 Theme 1: Importance of a shared, broad understanding of the scope of child protection issues by parents and guardians

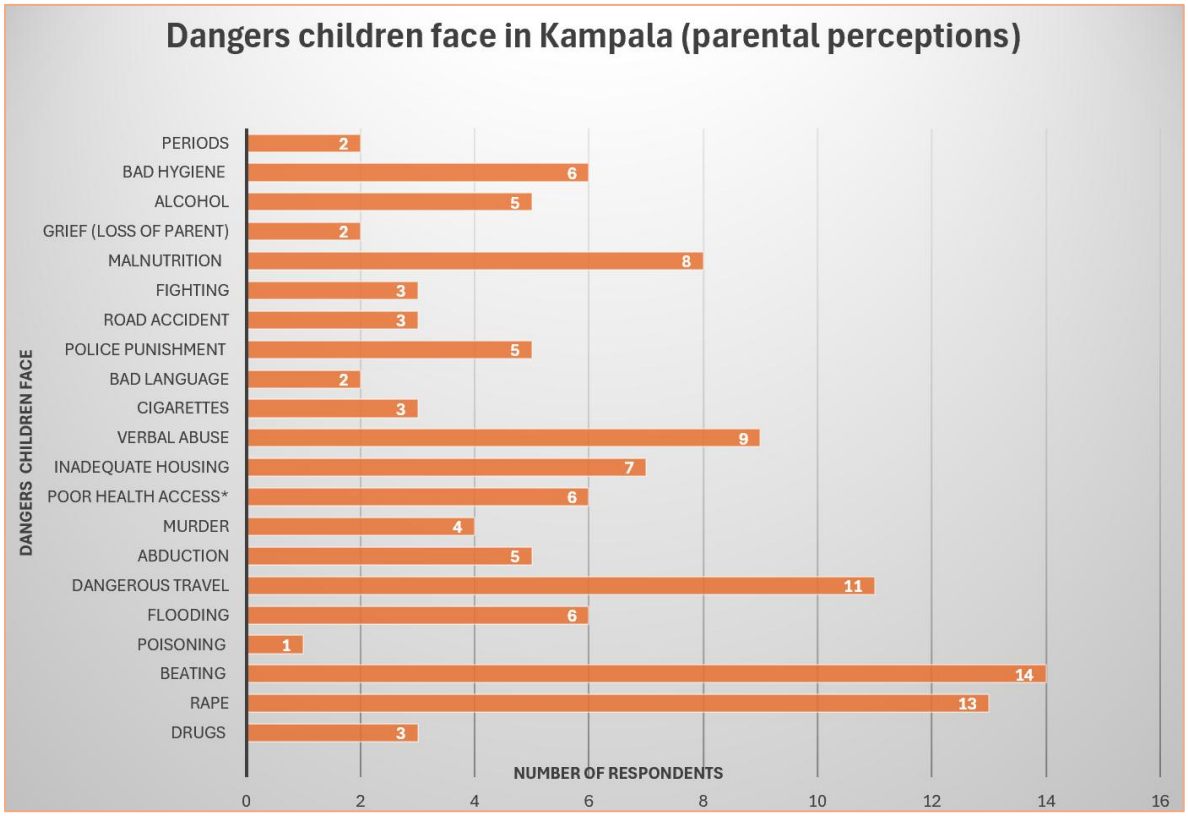
Each respondent was asked to define the concept of "child protection". For most respondents, this term was understood. For those who did not understand, the concept was translated to "how do you keep children safe?".

The analysis of how respondents define "child protection" reveals a significant conceptual difference between local knowledge and international frameworks. Interviews with parents/guardians demonstrated that their understanding of the term is predominantly practical and provision-based, centring on the tangible responsibilities of caregivers, such as providing food, clothing, shelter, and medical care. These definitions are closely aligned with those provided by KCK staff, who similarly emphasised a holistic approach to a child's fulfilment of their needs. This alignment suggests a successful transmission of KCK's working definition into the community it serves.

Respondents were also asked to describe the dangers children face in their communities (see **Figure 5**).

Figure 5

Dangers faced by children as perceived by their parents and guardians



** Example of poor health access is hospitals being too far away/ inaccessible.*

Author (2025)

These local perspectives, however, contrast the broader, rights-based international definitions of child protection, which encompass preventing and responding to abuse, neglect, exploitation, violence, and harmful practices. As articulated by UNICEF and UNHCR (2024), these frameworks are legally and conceptually distinct from the provision of basic needs. These findings, therefore, corroborate Wessells' (2015) assertion that local communities often hold fundamentally different views of childhood and potential harms than those enshrined in international standards. For example, while issues like CT, GBV and FGM are prevalent in Uganda, respondents (**as seen in Figure 5**) did not mention these terms once. This absence highlights a potential disconnection between international priorities and locally relevant perceptions of risk, suggesting that Western-centric concepts may not always resonate with the lived realities and cultural frameworks of a community.

These findings underscore the significance of locally defined concepts, and challenges the potential dominance of a top-down, Western interpretation of development and protection (Renzaho et al., 2018; Mugumbate et al., 2024). It argues for a more nuanced, reflexive approach to development practice that begins with local perspectives rather than imposing pre-defined solutions. The apparent success of KCK in communicating its child protection framework to the community demonstrates the value of this approach.

6.3 Theme 2: The impact of familial instability and poverty on parental ability to protect children

The research findings align with existing literature, which highlights the multi-layered barriers parents/guardians face in protecting children (Musendo, 2024). The analysis reveals that these challenges are often systemic, rooted in issues like financial and multi-dimensional poverty and familial instability (Save the Children, 2015; World Bank, 2016).

Interviews with participants corroborate this by identifying familial instability as a significant barrier. Several female respondents reported being divorced or abandoned by their child's father, who ceased communication and support. Familial instability, which can manifest as arguments, mistrust, and poor parenting, erodes vital informal support systems like extended family and community networks. The impact of such instability, combined with other factors like parental death, collectively heightens children's vulnerability within their primary care environments (Government of Uganda, 2020).

The impact of a husband's absence on a mother's capacity to protect her children was a recurrent theme. One respondent noted that in homes with "single mothers like me, [children] don't listen [to the parents]" (P12). The emotional and practical burden of this was a central concern for another mother, who shared, "My husband died in the church and left the children when they were young, so [I] went through a lot to make sure that [I] keep them" (P4). This sentiment was echoed by a third respondent who simply stated, "The father is not supporting me" (P8), highlighting the financial and emotional impact of a partner's absence.

The findings also indicate the erosion of traditional community values, such as the concept of 'Obuntu' (Mugumbate et al., 2024; Renzaho et al., 2018). One respondent's comment, "Fathers don't want to be with children whom they have not given birth to" (P9), highlights how rapid urbanisation can challenge traditional family ties. Consequently, biological fathers leaving without providing support (P6) was a common experience among respondents. This underscores how the erosion of traditional community responsibility, particularly regarding the protection of children regardless of biological status, is a significant challenge.

The issue of familial instability intersects with financial poverty, subsequently impacting parental capacity to protect their children. Female respondents consistently reported that a husband's abandonment, combined with financial destitution, directly hindered their protective capacity. This is exemplified by one mother's statement: "The other child's father is not helping. It's me trying to buy [school] books" (P6), highlighting the intersection of familial instability and financial poverty.

The research findings demonstrate a strong correlation between multidimensional poverty and child protection issues. The data from this study corroborate this, with 100% respondents articulating financial struggles that extend beyond income deficits. Respondents consistently described how financial hardship creates further challenges. Most notably, financial barriers directly impacted children's access to education. Comments like "challenge of school fees because they are not able to pay the money for their children" (P2) and "another challenge is paying school fees" (P7) were prevalent, highlighting education as significant impact of financial poverty.

The data illustrate how economic hardship intersects with challenges in food security, with one respondent stating, "there are some parents who can't afford even breakfast" (P3), while another

pointed to a broader environmental factor, noting that "the climate is a challenge in terms of providing [children] food" (P7).

Poverty also intersects with a lack of health and sanitation resources. The researcher observed a tone of sadness as one respondent (P9) admitted to the emotional and practical burden of being unable to afford sanitary pads, a critical issue of health and dignity. This finding corroborates Musendo's (2024) argument that neglect is often a consequence of external, uncontrollable factors rather than a lack of parental will.

Furthermore, some respondents' accounts highlighted the intersection of poverty with inadequate housing and infrastructure. They described the dangers of poor living conditions, such as multiple children sleeping in a "small" room (P1), and the risks associated with limited access to essential services, exemplified by the need to travel long distances to a hospital (P1).

The findings provide clear evidence of how multiple, overlapping vulnerabilities shape a parent's capacity for child protection, supporting an intersectional framework. The lived experiences of respondents demonstrate that financial poverty is not a single issue, but a complex network of interconnected deprivations. These deprivations collectively create significant barriers for caregivers.

6.4 Theme 3: Strategies employed by parents and guardians for child protection

6.4.1 Sub-theme 3.1: Child protection measures adopted by parents and guardians

Children in urban environments like Kampala navigate intersecting risks across their developmental stages (UNICEF, 2025) as shown in **Figure 5**. Interviews with respondents indicated a range of strategies to protect children. A summary of the strategies highlighted by respondents is given in **Table 7**. The long-term consequences of child protection violations, which include impacts on mental and physical health, educational attainment, and increased risks of substance abuse, underscore the critical importance of these parental efforts (Ellermeijer et al., 2023).

Table 7

Parental strategies to protect their children

	Number of respondents who highlighted the issue		
Strategies for protection	**Parents/ guardians**	**Alumni**	**TOTAL**
1. Ensuring pupil retainment at school	5	2	**7**
2. Protective strategies to keep children safe when travelling alone	11	2	**13**
3. Parents having open dialogue with their children, providing advice, counselling and guidance	13	1	**14**
4. Ensuring sufficient food and nutrition for children	4	1	**5**

Author (2025)

A significant finding from this study is the respondents' emphasis on preventative strategies as a primary mode of child protection. This approach reflects a growing awareness of child protection knowledge within the community. The word "prevent" was used frequently by respondents, signalling a shift to more preventative action.

Parents/guardians frequently cited the regulation of children's movement as a primary preventative measure. This was often managed through a collective supervision strategy, with parents detailing rules to mitigate risks. For example, one mother stated she does not "allow them to move individually. [The children] move in group" (P1), a sentiment echoed by another who insisted, "No one should leave the other behind. Do everything as a group" (P2). This proactive strategy is also reinforced through direct parental advice, as one respondent explained she advises her children "not being in dark corners at night, no moving alone. You have to move in a group" (P8).

In addition to group supervision, some parents adopted a more restrictive approach, limiting their children's time outside. They viewed the home and school as key safe spaces, as expressed by one respondent: "They take most of their time at school so it's safe, but at home they stay inside. I try to keep them inside" (P6). This strategy of containment was framed as a direct way to avoid external dangers such as traffic accidents (P13).

Beyond physical protection, parents also recognised the importance of strengthening the parent-child relationship and providing emotional support, aligning with research by Kafuko et al. (2015) and Wessells (2015). A key theme was counselling, described as an ongoing process of giving advice and fostering open communication. Respondents' comments, such as "counselling by telling [children] what is good" (P11) and "you keep on guiding them all the time" (P16), demonstrate this approach. The repetition of the word "counselling" four times by P13, delivered with a tone of urgency and confidence, suggests a growing capacity among parents to engage in this form of protection. Furthermore, one father's commitment to counselling, where he "makes sure that if they need something… he provides to make them feel good" (P5), illustrates an integrated approach to emotional and material support. This finding suggests that parental counselling is a recognised and valued strategy for building children's resilience against community dangers (P15).

The data also reveal that parents see basic provisions such as food, education, and shelter as fundamental intersecting components of child protection. This perspective is particularly relevant given the high rates of multidimensional poverty in Uganda (World Bank, 2016). Respondents frequently linked providing for their children's basic needs, directly to their protection. For example, ensuring children were fed was seen as a core protective action: "Have to make sure they get food. That's how you keep them safe" (P7). This even extended to creative, self-sufficient solutions like gardening to provide food (P3), highlighting the resilience and resourcefulness of parental figures.

The importance of education was a strong theme, echoing the findings of Kafuko et al. (2015) while also challenging a key assumption. Despite the literature noting that parental indifference often comes from their own limited education, this study's findings show that respondents, even with their own limited schooling, strongly valued and prioritised their children's education. Statements like "educating them, providing to them" (A1) and "encouraging them to keep in school" (P11) framed education as a protective measure against external dangers and negative peer influences.

Finally, a sense of collective responsibility emerged, indicating that while formal systems may be lacking, informal community-level protection mechanisms are active. Comments like "everyone has to help each other" (P2) and "we take [all children] like our own" (P3)

underscore the presence of community solidarity. These findings resonate with the concept of 'Obuntu' (Mugumbate et al., 2024).

However, the findings also challenge the notion of a perfectly cohesive community. As P3's comment indicates: "She keeps an eye on [her children] and doesn't give them to anyone else". While informal child protection is vital, it may be fragmented or unsafe (Wulczyn et al., 2010).

6.4.2 Sub-theme 3.2: Discipline imposed by parents and guardians for child protection

While informal systems of child protection are often culturally sensitive, their methods can sometimes diverge from international human rights standards (Terre des hommes & UNICEF, 2020). The findings from this study corroborate this by revealing that a significant number of respondents use corporal punishment and other forms of harsh discipline.

Respondents' statements frequently revealed the use of physical and verbal abuse, highlighting a common perception that these methods are a necessary component of effective parenting. For instance, one guardian stated, "I cane [my children]" (A1), while another defined their approach as "raising [my] voice towards and beating [children] if they do wrong" (P10). In a more extreme example of institutional violence, one parent noted that they "take them to police to get caned" (P12). The use of phrases like "tough parent" and "strong hand" by a respondent (P12) alongside observed confidence and smiling suggests that these disciplinary methods are often seen as essential for ensuring children's obedience rather than as a form of harm. These findings align with existing literature that highlights the complexities of parental discipline practices within specific cultural contexts (Terre des hommes & UNICEF, 2020).

This section underscores the critical point that what is considered a protective measure at the community level may be viewed as a human rights violation from an international perspective. This contrast is a central challenge in child protection, as it reveals the need for culturally informed approaches that bridge the gap between local norms and universal standards of child welfare.

6.5 Theme 4: The Influence of intergenerational parenting practices

The findings reveal a clear pattern of intergenerational transmission of parenting practices. Many parents/guardians who experienced violent discipline in childhood felt these same methods were appropriate for their own children, as articulated by one respondent who "didn't change her parenting" (P16) and another who stated, "I learned from [my mum], and that's what

I'm doing to my children" (P6). This influence was sometimes viewed with pride, with one participant emphasising how their upbringing "influenced" their current parenting style.

However, the study also found evidence of parents actively seeking to break this cycle. One respondent acknowledged that “as a parent, even me, I was making mistakes” and credited KCK with helping them recognise the need for change. This desire for a "better generation" and openness to alternative discipline methods was most evident among those who had engaged with KCK, reinforcing that culturally sensitive interventions can foster a shift away from harsh discipline (ICSAfrica, 2016; Musendo, 2024).

The influence of previous generations was not entirely negative. Some respondents acknowledged positive traits, such as the value of community-based child-rearing. As one respondent stated, "I wasn't raised by only a mother. I was raised by the community here" (P5). This finding is crucial as it suggests that the intergenerational cycle can also transmit positive, protective norms, such as a reliance on a collective network for child protection, which is consistently highlighted in the literature as a protective factor against child maltreatment (Byrne et al., 2012; Saitadze & Dvalishvili, 2024; Thompson, 2015).

P1's narrative illustrates this positive communal influence. Raised by her community, she learned "how to handle children" and developed essential skills for resilience and self-sufficiency, which she felt were crucial practical components of child protection. While her account demonstrates a positive transfer of communal values, it also reveals a conscious effort to break from less desirable aspects of her upbringing, such as a lack of open communication. When asked about her own parenting, she stated her approach would be "different," highlighting a parent's conscious agency and desire to change intergenerational patterns and foster emotional support in their own families.

Ultimately, the respondents' narratives underscore the dual nature of informal support: it can be a powerful source of positive values and resilience, but can also perpetuate harmful practices like corporal punishment. However, with exposure to new ideas and a desire for change, as seen with KCK's influence, parents are capable of deliberately moving away from harmful practices toward more open and supportive parenting.

6.6 Theme 5: The value of external support to parents and guardians from KCK

Through programme observations, staff consultations, and a review of KCK reports (KCK, 2025; VASHI, 2023), it was determined that KCK does not offer any dedicated programmes for parental figures that focus specifically on child protection training. Instead, supplementary parent meetings are integrated into some of their existing programmes.

Feedback from respondents underscored a significant, unmet demand among parents for practical knowledge and skills to protect their children from community dangers and to learn alternative, non-violent discipline. This demand is evidenced by the high attendance at KCK's ECD parent meetings, which attracted 38 participants against an expected turnout of 15. The strong expressed interest (90%) among parents highlights the perceived value and critical need for these gatherings.

However, a key finding is that these parent meetings function as a supplement to existing child protection initiatives rather than as a distinct engagement strategy. There is a clear gap in KCK's programming in educating parents/guardians with the specific knowledge and skills needed to actively protect their children.

The literature consistently highlights the importance of external support systems in mitigating parental stress and reducing the risk of child maltreatment (Saitadze & Dvalishvili, 2024; Byrne et al., 2012). This study's findings directly corroborate this, demonstrating the significant role that NGOs and community programmes play in strengthening parental capacity and fostering a protective environment for children. The respondents' narratives provide examples of how organisations like KCK function as a critical support network.

The findings show that community programmes are vital in connecting parents to both resources and knowledge. Respondents frequently described attending meetings and receiving advice, which directly addressed their parenting practices. For example, P4 highlighted the direct educational benefit of KCK:

> "Kids Club always tell [parents] that the way [they] teach the children in Kids Club is the same way [they] want [parents] to teach them back home."

This quote, along with P5's statement about KCK's advice to not be "harsh on children" and instead showing them love, show a deliberate effort by KCK to improve parenting methods, moving away from harsh discipline practices.

These programmes also serve as a space for community building. P3 noted the value of parent-teacher meetings, stating:

> "I personally attend parent meetings when they're organised [by KCK]. And sometimes the teachers visit us. They visit us at home to check on the child."

This active engagement not only provides educational guidance but also builds trust and reduces parental isolation that is a known risk factor for child maltreatment (Saitadze & Dvalishvili, 2024).

Respondents' feedback suggests that this external support significantly enhances their confidence and reduces stress. The support is seen as a "forceful burden being lifted" (A1), particularly when it comes to providing essential resources. As P13 explained, KCK's provision of schoolbooks "saved" parents/guardians from having to buy them, thereby reducing financial strain, directly linking to improved child protection outcomes (Save the Children, 2019).

The support provided by KCK extends beyond simple advice and material goods. It also includes tangible assistance for health and protection, which is crucial in a context of limited resources. One respondent described how KCK provided critical healthcare, stating:

> "KCK also took good care of [my son] health wise, [they] did some operation for him, and it was successful."

This direct intervention demonstrates the NGO's ability to fill gaps in public services and respond to immediate, life-threatening challenges.

The support also has a profound emotional and psychological impact. P2's comment,

> "[they] provide guidance and counselling how to take care of [problems], where to reach first, rather than keeping yourself quiet,"

highlights the importance of creating a space for parents to seek help and feel supported. This aligns with Thompson's (2015) research on the importance of reducing parental stress and enhancing psychological well-being for child safety. KCK parent meetings create a network where parents can connect with professionals and other parents and ultimately feel more supported in protecting their children.

These findings provide an opposing view to the critique that some NGOs prioritise their own visibility over long-term outcomes. The data show that organisations like KCK can be beneficial for increasing parental capacity to protect children, providing a holistic form of

support that includes educational, material, and emotional needs. Community-programmes effectively reduce parental isolation, enhance parenting skills, and build a community-level safety net for children. This aligns with the literature that calls for robust, community-based mechanisms to address and prevent child abuse (Save the Children, 2012). The positive changes in parental behaviour indicate that these interventions are not just temporary solutions but actively contribute to breaking intergenerational cycles of abuse and neglect.

6.7 Theme 6: Visions and aspirations for children's outcomes

Parental confidence and stress levels significantly impact caregiving, with low confidence and high stress often leading to negative behaviours (Huang, 2018; Musendo, 2024). This study explored how the strategic vision of KCK aims to address these issues and foster a more protective environment for children. The interview with a KCK safeguarding officer revealed that aspirations of KCK are to provide holistic parental support and a sustained effort to end harsh punishment of children (KCK 1). This approach goes beyond one-off interventions, focusing on "reminding parents of their responsibility" and "building their confidence" (KCK 1). This aligns with research highlighting that enhancing parenting skills and confidence can lead to significant positive changes within family dynamics (ICSAfrica, 2016; Wight et al., 2022).

6.7.1 Sub-theme 6.1: The importance of KCK aspirations for parents and guardians

The Vashi Report (2023) commissioned for KCK, identified a concern surrounding the sustainability of KCK interventions and their ability to produce lasting change. Evaluations of NGO programmes frequently seek to understand their long-term impact, particularly the extent to which they generate significant positive or negative, intended or unintended, higher-level effects after the project concludes (VASHI, 2023). A crucial aspect of these evaluations involves analysing the intersecting experiences of various groups, including distinct outcomes for women and men, as well as for other vulnerable groups. For example, one KCK project provides support that enables parents/guardians to better care for and provide for their children, through regular meetings with ECD teachers. These meetings help parents identify and address weak areas in their caregiving (VASHI, 2023).

However, a notable unintended consequence of such projects was noted as increased community dependency on KCK. This concern was directly corroborated by the findings of this study. A respondent observed that without KCK's continued assistance, families might

revert to their previous vulnerable state, struggling to feed and care for their children (P3). Despite this evident concern about NGO dependency, recommendations from the VASHI report did not address how to encourage parents to continue KCK child protection strategies at home.

A key focus of KCK's "sensitisation" effort is the promotion of non-violent disciplinary methods. Staff member KCK 2 explained their focus on communication over physical punishment, stating:

> "Beating isn't a punishment. We still have a long way to go by educating parents on children. We encourage parents to talk to their children... because by beating, the child may not change" (KCK 2).

The need for a continuum of care was also emphasised, with a focus on consistent dialogue, as counselling "must be consistent. [Parents] cannot talk to [children] once in a while, it has to be ongoing" (KCK 2).

These non-violent alternatives, such as denying privileges, align with the recommendations of the CRC and effective programme models that promote enhanced communication (Wight et al., 2022).

The KCK staff member's vision for disseminating this training highlights an innovative and contextually relevant strategy. They suggested using existing community structures to reach a wider audience, proposing:

> "to do market talks with a speaker where many people are gathered and we tell them about children's rights and what parents can do, then we can go on community radios" (KCK 2).

This emphasis on accessible platforms demonstrates a strategic understanding of the local context and a commitment to ensuring KCK's parental education efforts are effective and widely accessible.

Comments from KCK 2 reveal a vision that moves beyond one-off interventions. This approach emphasises "reminding parents of their responsibility and building their confidence", acknowledging that effective parenting requires both knowledge and self-assurance. The focus is on a "wholesome" effort where KCK consistently "sensitises" both parents and children to foster a "better generation" (KCK 2).

6.7.2 Sub-theme 6.2: The importance of the aspirations of parents and guardians to enhance child protection

KCK's mission statement states a commitment to:

> "a holistic approach, ensuring that children and families have their basic needs met (food, safety) so they can fully engage with and benefit from education and skills development" (KCK, 2025).

However, analysis of parental feedback indicates that this holistic aspiration is not being fully realised. Parents/guardians articulated a clear, unmet need for their children's protection. This desire for continued external support manifested in two main, intersecting categories: a demand for direct parental training and a call for systemic improvements to their broader living conditions.

Many respondents demonstrated a strong sense of parental agency by actively seeking continued guidance from KCK. They expressed a desire for further parental training, showing they value KCK's expertise and view the learning process as ongoing. One parent stated, "I would like further [parental training]", while another specifically requested advice on "discipline, on hygiene, on keeping themselves safe". This desire for continued support, particularly the request for advice on discipline, which one parent acknowledged would involve a conversation about their use of corporal punishment, "I know [KCK will] tell me I'm supposed to not [beat]", underscores a clear recognition of the need for change and a willingness to learn.

Crucially, parental aspirations extended beyond personal training to a demand for systemic change, directly supporting the study's intersectional framework. Their requests for improved conditions demonstrate a clear understanding of how broader, structural deprivations impact their ability to protect their children. For instance, while some parents expressed a desire for their children to be "happy, going to school, getting their destiny," others made more tangible demands, such as for KCK to "help pay school fees." This focus on systemic issues was especially evident in requests related to infrastructure and healthcare. One parent highlighted the need for better sanitation, requesting improved trenches and more toilets (P12). Another spoke of the high cost of private clinics and the lack of medicines in government hospitals, stating that if "that is revised... at least parents will be in a position to be helped" (P15).

These responses reveal that parents connect their children's safety to a network of interconnected vulnerabilities. As one respondent noted:

> "if the conditions of life were better... I don't think these children will also live in such areas of danger" (P3),

while another linked a lack of basic services directly to child mortality, stating:

> "we would not have a death problem with our children if we could go to a hospital " (P3).

This demonstrates that parents/guardians in Kampala perceive child protection as a complex challenge shaped by the intersection of poverty, unstable family structures, and inadequate community infrastructure. This lived experience directly corroborates the study's intersectional lens, showing that a parent's capacity to protect their child is a product of multiple, overlapping factors.

The shared aspirations of both KCK staff and the parental figures reveal a mutual vision for a more educational environment for parents. KCK's focus on parental support and non-violent discipline aligns directly with the parents' desire for tangible resources and continued training. The KCK staff member's innovative ideas for dissemination, such as using community radio and market talks, show a practical approach to fulfilling these aspirations. However, the parents' aspirations introduce a critical call for systemic change in healthcare, sanitation, and housing. This suggests that while NGOs play a vital role in skills training, long-term child protection ultimately depends on addressing the wider structural inequalities that create risk. The findings suggest that interventions that combine parental skills training with advocacy for improved living conditions are essential for creating a truly protective environment within Kampala's slum settlements and surrounding villages.

Chapter 7: Conclusion

This qualitative study investigated the complex impact of NGO support on child protection, focusing specifically on the lived experiences of parents/guardians in Kampala's slum settlements. By centring the analysis on the initiatives of KCK, this research utilised an intersectional framework to thematically analyse data from semi-structured interviews and observations. The researcher is grateful for the time and resources of KCK staff and local respondents, which led to rich understanding of the challenges and aspirations of parental figures and KCK.

The study revealed several key findings with significant implications for future research. The findings suggest that parents/guardians in Kampala's slum settlements and surrounding villages express a strong desire for additional parent-skills training on child protection measures for the home environment, outside of KCK's direct projects. While they report high satisfaction with the support their children receive from KCK, significant barriers within the home and community affect their ability to implement these protective strategies.

7.1 Limitations

7.1.1 Interview environment

All parent interviews were conducted outside. The external environment posed significant challenges to the interview process. The noise from construction, children playing, and passing vehicles often made it difficult to hear responses clearly and meant there were often gaps to fill in the transcription, but this was dealt with by carefully reviewing the transcript after each interview.

7.1.2 Social desirability

The translation process introduced several potential limitations to the validity of the data. Translator bias and their interpretation of the research aims may have influenced the reliability of the translations (Bannigan and Watson, 2009). As noted by Kapborg and Bertero (2002), translators might inadvertently exclude content (failing to inform the researcher of negative opinions expressed about KCK for fear or repercussions). The researcher acknowledged the

risk of researcher and translator influence by speaking with translators before and after interviews to ensure unbiased translations were being made.

7.1.3 Linguistic challenges

Despite the reflexive measures undertaken to address translation challenges (as detailed in Section 5.4 Positionality and Reflexivity), the process of translating interview data from Luganda to English introduced potential limitations. The inherent difficulty in finding exact linguistic translations for certain concepts such as "child protection", mixed with the influence of the translator's interpretation, may have altered the original meaning of respondents' responses (McKenna, 2022). While efforts were made to ensure reliability, the nuances of the data's original context may not be fully preserved, thus impacting the ultimate validity of findings (Bannigan and Watson, 2009).

7.1.4 Sampling

Limited number of field locations (3 slums out of 10) and respondents (16 parents/guardians) contributes to a lack of generalisability. To mitigate this, the researcher used purposive sampling to achieve diversity in the samples.

7.1.5 Intersectional framework

While intersectionality has gained popularity, its application remains challenging. Some critiques note that it can sometimes lead to a focus on victimhood and the singling out of marginalised groups (Brahm, 2019). Researchers must avoid reducing individuals to a set of identity characteristics without considering their relevance, as this can be detrimental (McCall, 2005; Funer, 2023). Despite its vital role in informing research, the methodological implementation of intersectionality requires continuous critical engagement (Collins 2015). To mitigate these challenges, this study focused on the intersectional interplay of variables, such as how the experiences of parents/guardians were shaped by their gender, socioeconomic status and more (Thomas et al., 2023).

7.2 Impact and dissemination

The researcher recognises the strengths in the provision of KCK programmes to support children. While KCK's current initiatives have successfully improved community trust (KCK Impact Report, 2023; VASHI Final Report, 2023), the findings from this study indicate that

many respondents express a reliance on KCK for support. They also expressed a desire for greater agency in implementing their own child protection strategies at home.

The findings reveal a nuanced picture of child protection within these communities, which is shaped by the intersection of systemic challenges, including financial poverty, limited access to education, and the effects of climate change, such as seasonal flooding. Within this context, parents/guardians articulated a strong desire to break cycles of generational abuse, predominantly physical, yet expressed a critical need for enhanced resources and parental training beyond the scope of the organisation's current projects to do so. This highlights a clear gap in programming, suggesting that for long-term child protection to be sustainable, there must be a greater focus on educating parental figures.

7.3 Implications for Future Research

This research addressed the identified gaps in the literature, particularly the over-reliance on Western-based models of child protection (Kithome et al., 2021; Wulczyn et al., 2010). By highlighting the critical role of parents/guardians in the success of child protection efforts, this study offers a new perspective on how interventions can be designed. The findings suggest a shift away from top-down, single-issue focused approaches towards collaborative approaches that strengthen existing community resources (Brahm 2019; Collins, 2015).

For future research, comparative case-studies in different cultural and geographical contexts, particularly other non-western urban centres, would be beneficial to test the generalisability of the findings (Bowling, 2014). This would help determine whether the importance of community-led child protection efforts is a universal theme or specific to the context of Kampala.

Furthermore, future studies could employ quantitative methods, such as large-scale household surveys, to triangulate the data and explore the prevalence of the themes identified in this study on a broader scale (Flick, 2018; Herbet, 2000). This would provide a more comprehensive understanding of the factors that impact parents' capacity to protect their children across a wider population.

Ultimately, this research underscores the value of a holistic approach to child protection that moves beyond single-issue interventions (Brahm 2019; Collins, 2015). By providing further evidence for the critical role of parents/guardians in long-term child protection, the study

contributes to a growing knowledge that advocates for NGO programming to be more parent-centric. The findings of this research show the resilience and willingness of parental figures to protect their children, as well as the impactful work of organisations like KCK in creating an environment for this change.

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Appendices

Appendix 1

Overview of KCK's programmes

Programme	Details
Saturday Kids Club	Provides a safe space for play and care for up to 500 children across 10 slums, run by local volunteers, includes nutritious food and counselling for children.
Girls Support Groups	Offers safe spaces for counselling, peer support, and education on topics like health, personal security, and teenage pregnancy, along with access to period products.
Football Project	Uses football to mentor children, improve their confidence and teamwork, and provide counselling and nutritious snacks.
Educating	Recognising that a lack of free education contributes to the cycle of poverty, KCK provides free daily education and a nutritious meal to out-of-school children in some of Kampala's poorest slums in the Early Childhood Development (ECD) programmes.
Skilling	Offers free vocational training and business courses for both parents and young people to help them generate income and achieve financial independence. Specific initiatives include tailoring and knitting courses for women and a 12-month carpentry project for young men and boys.
EWAFE	Children's centre for reuniting children with families or rehabilitating and re-homing children into safe foster homes.